

'We want freedom to innovate and experiment'

With two-thirds of the population under 35, the world's largest democracy can dare to dream. Five young Indians from different backgrounds come together to help us understand both the dreams, and the nightmares. Participating in the discussion are a group of young professionals and parliamentarians: Jayant Chaudhary, 30, a first time MP from Mathura from the Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) and Chaudhary Charan Singh's grandson; Deepender Hooda, 31, another third generation politician and MP from Rohtak whose current project is the democratisation of the Youth Congress; Janardhana Swamy, 41, from the BJP, an NRI from the Silicon Valley before he flew in to contest from Chitradurga in Karnataka; Vibha Galhotra, 31, contemporary artist and sculptor; and Ratish Nanda, 36, a conservation architect who has worked on many projects in India and Afghanistan. The debate was moderated by Associate Editors Sandeep Unnithan and Priya Sahgal. Excerpts.

Jayant Chaudhary If I may quote Sharad Pawar, I am not an astrologer, so I really can't say what shape this decade will take. But our demographic dividend should propel our country, in the next 20-30 years, to a position where development is more democratised. Till now, we have taken a very limited and urban view of development. The key challenges, I prefer this word to opportunities, are education and basic infrastructure.

Vibha Galhotra Art has changed from being only a pictorial refreshment to becoming a statement which affects the social and political life of the country. However, I am looking for the freedom of expression, for innovations and experimentation by the new generation.

Deepender Hooda The youth need to shift from agriculture to manufacturing and services at a much faster pace. We have to ensure that our growth trajectory not only fulfills the demands of the growing population but also achieves something sustain-

able over the future. The nature of political debate must shift from divisive lines to development. The Congress is trying to empower youth by bringing in internal party democracy.

Ratish Nanda As Mahatma Gandhi said, Earth has enough for every man's needs, not for every man's greed. The quality of life of the average citizen is going down and apathy is building. It is up to the youth to demand an improvement in the quality of life and involve civil society. The government cannot do it alone. Heritage is one aspect which does not need to be looked anymore as monument centric. We have to get over the fact that we have the Taj Mahal. The NREGA needs to shift its employment-only focus towards sustainable projects.

Janardhana Swamy Education needs to focus on ensuring that what we study ends up in what we understand. We have travelled from being a technology observer to becoming a technology follower. As long as the cost of getting



(L TO R)
NANDA,
CHAUDHARY,
GALHOTRA,
SWAMY
AND HOODA

"It is up to the youth to demand improvement in the quality of life and involve civil society."

RATISH NANDA

Conservation Architect

elected remains high in this country, corruption will live. Rs 25 lakh is the expenditure limit for a candidate. If a candidate does not follow rules, this means he becomes a law-breaker before becoming a law-maker.

INDIA TODAY Change is the buzzword these days. The youth, however, don't seem to be challenging the system but getting merged in it.

Nanda Ever since Mandal Commission, has the youth agitated about anything? What about civil society? Everybody is dependent on the judiciary for making changes. What happens if the judiciary collapses? We